JUSTIN HAMMER



Justin Hammer first appeared in Iron Man #120, in 1979. Like the purpose-built specialty armor, Hammer was introduced by the classic Iron Man creative team of David Michelinie, Bob Layton, and John Romita Jr. While a character like Crimson Dynamo was the opposite of Iron Man—a super villain in armor—Hammer was a different paradigm: he was the evil opposite of Tony Stark.

"The type of corporate war that would go on between [Stark] and someone like Justin Hammer, I found fascinating," says Marvel Comics Senior Editor—and current Invincible Iron Man editor—Ralph Macchio. "They'd be fighting on so many different levels, because they'd have their tentacles in so many financial institutions and so many organizations and so many corporations. Stark Enterprises was so sprawling, and Hammer Industries was as well, and to have them going at it, to me was very interesting."

That dynamic was quite different than the sort of relationships most super heroes had with their villains. In many ways, Macchio says he was excited by this dynamic "more so than having another guy in armor or another super villain. This was Tony Stark having to use his smarts, his financial empire, and putting it on the line to fight somebody who's just as deadly as anybody in a costume was."



Jon Favreau sees Hammer as "the fellow who is probably a notch below Tony, but fancies himself Tony Stark. And is definitely competitive with him, as many people on that level are very competitive. Even though they have more money than they know what to do with, they still are haunted at night that there is somebody who is better than them. And so that's Justin Hammer."



Iron Man 2 might not be the last we see of Hammer. Jeremy Latcham explains, "We definitely took steps to make sure that Justin Hammer didn't get killed at the end of Iron Man 2 because we're going to want to see him again. He's a compelling guy, he's got a lot to say, he has a relationship with Tony Stark, there's like a ton of reasons why you want him alive and around to kind of pop up later. He took the Mark II and modified it to the War Machine armor, so he's a smart guy. He's just not exactly a good guy."

Art by Mark Bagley (left), John Romita Jr. (middle), Carmine Infantino (right).